Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 6 4
♥ 7 3 2
♦ A 8 5 4 2
♣ 6 5

♠ Q 10 7 2
♥ Q 9 4
♦ Q 10 9
♣ J 10 7

♠ J 8 3
♥ J 10 8 5
♦ K J
♣ Q 9 8 3

♠ A K 5
♥ A K 6
♦ 7 6 3
♣ A K 4 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and East the ♠J.

West plays low.

East wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners and dummy's ♦suit is your only hope. **IF** ♦s split 3-2 and **IF** the defenders don't take too many winners in their suit(s) you can establish ♦s by ducking twice.

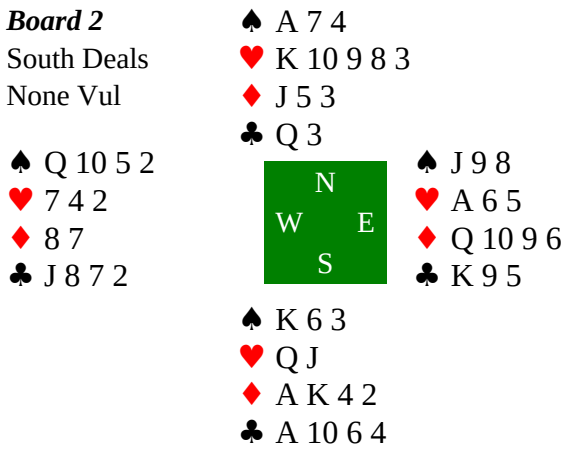
Win the first ♠. If you hold up they might pocket the ♠ trick and switch to another suit where you only have two stoppers.

Next play a small ♦ from each hand. Win the return (probably a ♠) and duck a second ♦.

If the defenders can only take 2 ♠ tricks now you are home-free since dummy's 3 ♦s are now established.

You had to have the defender's ♠s split 4-3. But in fact you were pretty sure they were going to do so. Since West's ♠2 was probably his fourth-down then he couldn't have a fifth-down.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

North's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2.

East plays the ♠J and you win with the ♠K.

West plays low.

East plays low too.

West plays low.

East holds up his ♥A again.

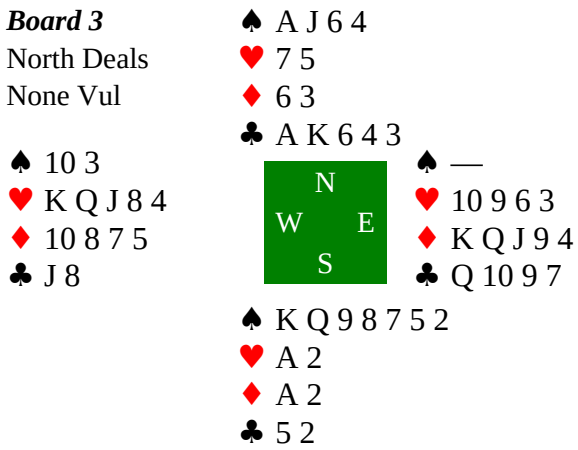
Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 5

Obviously you need to establish 4 ♥ winners and by driving out the ♥A you can manage that handily. The problem is that dummy has only one sure entry, (the ♠A), and the defenders may be good enough to hold up their ♥A twice.

To assure the contract you should win the first trick in your hand with the ♠K. Then play ♥Q, ♥J overtaking with dummy's ♥K so you can continue establishing the suit while you still have that ♠ entry.

None of the other suits were sitting well so overtaking the ♥ was the way to go.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥5 and East the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and draw trumps with the ♠K and ♠Q.

West plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

One of the two red losers must be discarded on dummy's ♣ suit. So you pull trumps, taking two rounds, with ♠K and ♠Q. Then play two top ♣s and ruff a ♣. When West shows out on the third ♣, enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♣. Dummy's final ♣ is now established, so enter dummy with another trump and discard one of the red losers on the fifth ♣.

As long as the ♣s were no worse than 4-2 you can establish the suit.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A J 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ Q 6 4 3	
♠ K 6 4 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ K 10 8 6 2 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ A 8 ♥ Q 10 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 9 7
	♠ Q J 5 ♥ K 5 4 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
All Pass			

1NT by South
Lead: ♦6

South is to play 1NT. West leads the ♦6, taken by East with the ♦J. East next plays the ♦Q on which West plays the ♦2. East plays the ♦9 which you finally win.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

You only need one more winner and you have several possibilities. The ♥ finesse might work, or the ♣s might split 3-3. But you need to consider the defenders winners also. They have already scored 2 ♦ tricks and will get 2 more as soon as they gain the lead. (The spot cards told you that West has a 5-card ♦ suit.) Plus they have the 2 top ♠s which they can take whenever they like. So if your play sets up just one more trick for them you will go down.

No, you must establish ♠s, the suit where they have 2 winners anyway. So you play a ♠ which West wins. He takes his 2 ♦s but you are now home free. When you gain the lead again you will get your ♠ winner established and only lose 2 ♠s and 4 ♦s.

If you finessed the ♥ you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♥ and 2 ♠s.

If you had played 3 rounds of ♣s you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♣ and 2 ♠s.

Only by establishing ♠s can you make the contract.